

**Bridging Generations: Harnessing Intergenerational Collaboration to Combat Ageism and
Foster Inclusivity in the Workplace**

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As a result of the technology sector constantly evolving, diversity and inclusion have become principal factors for facilitating innovation. Although other social issues are equally important, one issue is overlooked: ageism. This is a type of discrimination characterized by bias against workers of a specific age group. This work aims to focus primarily on older workers who are commonly disadvantaged in the hiring process and in career advancement opportunities. In recognition of this, the paper will suggest that intergenerational collaboration is a key strategy to combat against ageist practices. This would improve workplace productivity by combining the skills and knowledge of all age groups. This research also aims to examine how intergenerational collaboration can be applied to promote diversity, assist in the transfer of knowledge, and eliminate ageism in the technology industry.

Understanding Ageism

Prevalence of Ageism

The technology industry, which is praised for its innovation and forward-looking approach, ironically remains as a place for ageism. This is a widespread barrier that disrupts the industry's ethical standards. Anna Kidron, a marketing manager for a software development company known as Elinext, highlights that “people who work in the tech and IT sectors” are likely to “start experiencing ageism” as early as age 29, according to the results of a survey by CWJobs (Kidron, 2022). This is much earlier than other industries in the survey, including finance, manufacturing, education, retail, health care, and the public sector. Likewise, Brett Shively, the CEO of ACI Learning, emphasizes the “stubbornly pervasive” nature of ageism in the field (Shively, 2023). He identifies the problem as something that mutually harms both

companies and tech professionals who are older and experienced, especially “during a time of widespread labor shortages” (Shively, 2023). These observations highlight a concerning trend: although the industry is quickly advancing, its way of addressing age diversity is hindered by unfair stereotypes.

Stereotypes and Misconceptions

The cycle of ageism is maintained by stereotypes and misconceptions about older workers in the tech industry, due to the way the industry values fast-paced modernization and adaptability. These stereotypes portray older workers as being less likely to adapt to newer technologies. Psychology professors at the West Chester University of Pennsylvania conducted research on the issue by analyzing 244 responses to a survey, with “128 identified as female” (McConatha, Kumar, Magnarelli, & Hanna, 2023). Fifty-one percent of female respondents admitted to experiencing “some form of age discrimination,” with most being at least age 50 (McConatha, Kumar, Magnarelli, & Hanna, 2023). This data suggests that ageism also intersects with gender, which complicates the biases even further. The professors’ research demonstrates how these stereotypes disadvantage a substantial portion of the workforce by underrating their capability of making valuable contributions to their workplaces. This misconception leads to a workforce that lacks diverse viewpoints and experiences, which is essential for innovative solutions to various problems.

Consequences of Ageism

Impact on Career Advancement

The nature of ageism occurs primarily in the availability of career advancement opportunities, if any, to older individuals. Ageism constructs barriers that serve as a disadvantage to experienced professionals, which reduces their professional growth and ability to contribute to

the industry. According to Templeton & Partners, a tech recruitment agency that prioritizes diverse talent and ethical and recruitment practices, many biases occur unconsciously. Biases are often conducted by individuals “whose pre-formed opinions and preferences count against someone in a disadvantaged” group (Templeton, 2023). Their analysis suggests that there are changes that hiring managers can make that will promote a “a fair, equal and inclusive hiring process” (Templeton, 2023). These include removing biased phrases from job advertisements, and appointing individuals with varying ages and backgrounds to the interview panel to promote fairer treatment during interviews. These recruitment strategies would assist in removing unconscious biases from the overall hiring process.

Recruitment Practices

Aside from avoiding age-related biases in job descriptions, there are other solutions that employers should consider, which would assist in the inclusion older job seekers in employment opportunities. According to MRINetwork, a global recruitment organization, employers can implement blind resume screening, and offer training programs that can support older individuals. Blind resume screening gets its name by removing specific types of personal information, which could otherwise “result in favoritism or the exhibition of personal biases” (MRINetwork, 2023). This would remove the candidate’s name, year of graduation, and any other information that could be attributed to their age, gender, or ethnicity. Another option is to offer training programs, especially those that are focused on upskilling and reskilling opportunities. Reskilling would be necessary if the individual is going to move into a new role, but upskilling focuses on improving preexisting abilities by updating them with newer related knowledge, such as certification courses. By combining these practices with identifying a

potential job candidate's current skillset, employers can successfully give all applicants a fair chance regardless of age, and additionally provide new hires with the best training outcomes.

Impact on Well-being

The effects of ageism expand beyond just professionally, but also personally through the well-being and overall satisfaction of older employees' role in the technology industry.

Researchers from the National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH) have studied the effects of workplace ageism on multiple levels, by focusing on how the issue affects individuals' physical and psychological health. They associate perceived ageism among older employees with reduced job satisfaction, and "decreased organizational productivity, worsening of intergroup relations; and counterproductive work behaviors" (Petery & Grosch, 2022). The sensation of feeling marginalized or ignored based on age can result in decreased confidence, increased stress, and in severe cases, an early exit from their job. This negative reaction not only directly affects specific individuals, but it also indirectly harms the effectiveness of teamwork. The researchers also imply that these health outcomes affect health care costs, which was previously valued at "approximately \$63 billion in the United States over a single year" (Petery & Grosch, 2022). By facilitating a work environment that values respect and inclusion, tech companies can mitigate the alarming effects of ageism, resulting in the mutual benefit of both the well-being of employees and overall organizational performance.

Legal and Ethical Considerations

The perseverance of ageism in the technology industry not only presents ethical problems, but also questions legal considerations regarding employment practices. The UK Care Guide, an online resource that provides guidance for individuals in mid to later life stages, published a video last year that discusses the complexities and legal matters associated with age

discrimination. Although the video was published by a group based in the United Kingdom, it discusses legal protections in the United States, such as the Age Discrimination in Employment Act of 1967. However, it is true that age discrimination laws will “vary by country and might not cover workers of all ages” (UK Care Guide, 2023). For example, the labor law passed in the United States focuses on protecting individuals who are at least 40 years of age. Unfortunately, as other research previously mentioned in the paper, some individuals within some industries have commonly felt the effects of ageism prior to age 40. This highlights a critical issue: while companies may be complying with the law, they might not necessarily be making ethical decisions among all ages.

The Dynamics of Age Diversity in the Workplace

Benefits of Diversity and Inclusion

The pursuit of diversity and inclusion in the technology industry serves as an initiative to promote innovation, creativity, and mutual advantages for employees and employers alike. Embracing age diversity can support a work environment that will benefit from a wide range of experiences, viewpoints, and skillsets that employees of all ages have to offer. The previously mentioned global recruitment organization known as MRINetwork has cited industry reports which “predict that over 150 million jobs worldwide” are likely to shift to workers that are largely “over the age of 55 by 2030” (MRINetwork, 2023). Therefore, there is reason to believe that the needs of both employees and employers need to be addressed to ensure that everyone can reach their professional and business-related goals. Furthermore, an illustrative example from OpenAI, depicted through an image generated by Dall-E, provides a visual representation of the potential of generational collaboration within the workplace (OpenAI, 2024).

Figure 1

Illustration of Harmonious Generational Collaboration



Note. This figure illustrates a conceptual representation of harmonious generational collaboration. Created by OpenAI's DALL-E on March 17, 2024, and retrieved from <https://chat.openai.com/g/g-2fkFE8rbu-dall-e/c/bc2094bd-33d5-496e-82f7-6628b00c84dd>.

This image (Figure 1) serves as a symbol of the unity and strength of a diverse team, which represents the concept of how individuals of all age groups can work together to create a valuable, more productive, and innovative work culture. Altogether, these sources portray a convincing idea of the value of an age-diverse workgroup, which argues that the integration of older workers is more than just an ethical decision; it is also a strategic decision that can have a positive impact on a company's long-term success.

Strategies for Combating Ageism through Intergenerational Collaboration

Promoting Awareness and Understanding

Promoting awareness of the issue across all generations serves as a foundational step towards discouraging ageist stereotypes. Nihat P., a content creator for LinkedIn, published an article last year that discusses how to implement intergenerational collaboration. He provides examples of how some of today's largest technology companies have been successful at approaching ageism through various initiatives. For example, Amazon has developed "cross-generational project teams" who have worked together for various product launches, which combines "fresh ideas with experienced decision-making" (P., 2023). For example, experienced workers can provide hardware, software, and cybersecurity knowledge, while younger workers can introduce "innovative ideas" with their "understanding of modern technologies and trends" (P., 2023). This provides evidence of how intergenerational collaboration can help businesses continually evolve by allowing all ages to utilize their varying ideas and skills.

Creating Opportunities for Collaboration

Intergenerational collaboration should not only be seen as a benefit, but also as something that is essential for growth and development in the technology industry. Establishing opportunities for employees of various ages to collaborate can diminish stereotypes, facilitate the

transfer of knowledge, and provide plenty of learning opportunities. For example, Nihat P. also discussed Google's "G2G" initiative, which encourages continuous learning through its employee-to-employee network. Not only do programs of its kind allow for the transfer of industry-specific knowledge, but it also provides the opportunity to exchange diverse viewpoints, resulting in improved creativity and problem-solving abilities in a team setting. Brett Shively of ACI Learning further supports this idea, by citing a survey that found that companies managed by teams consisting of "above-average diversity in age, gender, career path, nationality, and education level" reported innovation revenue that was "19 percentage points higher than" those consisting of "below-average diversity" (Shively, 2023).

An image obtained from Flickr captures a moment of elders and younger adults working together to learn new technological skills (Proffitt, 2019).

Figure 2

Photograph of a Group Around Laptop



Note. This figure shows a group of individuals gathered around a laptop, illustrating the potential of diverse age groups collaborating to achieve their professional goals. Photograph by L. Proffitt (2019, April 13). Retrieved from <https://flic.kr/p/2frPUqo>.

This image (Figure 2), demonstrating age-diverse employees engaged in a shared task, serves as an example of how such teams can overcome myths associated with age and productivity in the technology industry.

Implementing Organizational Policies

To support the idea of creating more opportunities for intergenerational collaboration, companies should also create DEI (Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion) policies. These can combat

workplace ageism by providing employees with the necessary support and resources through employee resource groups (ERGs). Age-based teachings can also be included within a company's DEI initiative, which is designed to outline "the discriminatory acts of ageism, repercussions," and provide guidance on how to report "suspected cases of discrimination" (MRINetwork, 2023). These policies equip employees with the tools to overcome ageist practices, especially if the policies are reviewed regularly to ensure they remain relevant and effective in the ever-evolving nature of the technology industry.

Conclusion and Call for Change

This paper has highlighted the persistent issue of ageism within the technology sector, discussing its harmful effects on older employees in the context of career advancement, hiring processes, and overall well-being. By conducting a detailed examination of stereotypes and misconceptions, legal and ethical considerations, and the benefits of diversity and inclusion, it becomes clear that intergenerational collaboration is not just a benefit, but a necessity for an inclusive and productive workforce. The strategies this paper discusses, including promoting awareness, creating collaboration opportunities, and implementing organizational policies, provides a roadmap for technology companies to address ageism effectively. It is important to recognize that these initiatives require more than just policy changes; it needs a cultural shift. A shift towards valuing the contributions from individuals of all ages, and encouraging shared learning, teamwork, and mutual respect. This paper serves as a call to action for tech industry leaders to take steps to eliminate ageism and welcome generational diversity. As a result, companies will not only comply with legal and ethical standards, but they will also realize the extended potential of their workforce based on the contributions of all employees throughout the age spectrum.

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